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SHOW OF SOLIDARITY
Kashmiri traders observe a candlelight vigil at Lal Chowk in Srinagar, Apr. 23

corps commander in protest. Munir responded with a harsh crackdown and also sacked PTI backers in the army, but considerable damage was done to the military's credibility. Meanwhile, the Shehbaz Sharif-led coalition government is seen as completely indebted to the army for its survival.

More trouble is building with the infighting among the ruling coalition's main partners, the Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) or PML(N), to which Shehbaz belongs, and its one-time arch-foe, the Pakistan People's Party (PPP), of which President Asif Zardari is the co-chairperson. Differences between the two political frenemies came to a head recently over a canal project to supply Indus river water to Cholistan in southern Punjab. The PPP, which rules the Sindh province, complained that the project would deprive them of their share of water; its leader Bilawal Zardari Bhutto even threatened to pull out of the coalition if the issue was not resolved. In this situation, India's move to suspend the Indus Waters Treaty can exacerbate these divisions and prove an effective punitive measure that will give Pakistan pause.

If there is any consolation for Pakistan, it is in the modest signs of recovery the economy is showing, helped in large part by the first few tranches of the International Monetary Fund (IMF)'s $7 billion bailout. In a positive sign, the country's GDP grew at 2.5 per cent last year; it was $337 billion in 2023 compared to India's $3.5 trillion. As Ajay Bisaria, former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan, puts it, "The economy has moved out of the ICU but is still in the critical care ward. But it may sink again as, so far, there are no structural reforms to ensure sustained growth." Munir seems to have extended his influence here as well, becoming a member of the Special Investment Facilitation Council (SIFC) Shehbaz formed last July. Such a council, the Pakistan premier had argued, was necessary for "a unified approach" to steer the country out of the economic crisis, as he mandated it to frame economic policies. Members of the army brass will be national coordinators for both the apex and the executive committee.

IN A MAJOR TURNING POINT, MUCH OF THE VALLEY HAS CONDEMNED THE PAHALGAM ATTACK AS HAVE POLITICAL PARTIES ACROSS THE SPECTRUM

Munir, who took over as army chief in November 2022, has also ensured that he will continue for five years instead of three through a specially enabled legislation in Parliament last November. But with the army's credibility waning, especially after the train hijack by Baloch rebels and rising terror strikes across Pakistan by others, he is leveraging the Kashmir issue to deflect attention from the country's own internal crises. In a speech to the Overseas Pakistanis Convention in Islamabad on April 16, six days before the Pahalgam attack, Munir invoked Kashmir, saying, "Our stance is absolutely clear, it (Kashmir) was our jugular vein, it will be our jugular vein, we will not forget it. We will not leave our Kashmiri brothers in their heroic struggle." In the same speech, Munir also revived the two-nation theory and its continued relevance, which for Bisaria is reminiscent of the Islamic orthodoxy of General Zia-ul-Haq's reign in the 1980s. "General Munir was basically trying to rally people around the flag and break Imran's support among overseas Pakistanis," he says. "He was also garnering support with the army and, by taking up the Kashmir cause, hoping to strengthen his internal position, besides bolstering the mullah-military alliance." Experts see it as a key reason for Munir taking the huge gamble of escalating tensions with India and perhaps authorising the Pahalgam attack.

Sabharwal believes there were clear signs of Pakistan getting ready to attack. In the run-up to the strike, the establishment had issued strong statements accusing India of interference in Balochistan and warning of action against the militants and their backers. Despite a ceasefire at the LoC in place since 2021, there has been renewed volatility and border transgressions in recent weeks. Last year, too, ahead of the assembly election in J&K, Pakistan-backed militants had